decided that operations should be resumed vigorously.[62] Pandithurai Thevar came to Tuticorin and spent a day closeted in a meeting with S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and S. Parthasarathy.[63] As the most committed members—demonstrated by their heavy financial investment and the expenditure of enormous time and energy—the foursome probably met first before meeting with a larger group of directors and investors.

After the formal meeting, an exhaustive report was prepared, signed by nine directors: A. Sundara Sastri; T.S. Subramania Pillai; N.P.R.M.V.R.M. Alagappa Chettiar; V.A.A. Adinarayana Chettiyar; A.C.V. Tiruchittrambalam Chettiyar; V.A.V.S. Venkatachalam Chettiar; S.S.V. Krishna Pillai; S. Annaswami Aiyar and S.T.A. Arumugam Pillai. This straight-from-the-mouth-of-the-horse report provides as it were a snapshot of the company in mid-1909 and we have drawn heavily from it as our footnote references show.

The report proposed that once the company resumed operations, the results should be placed in a meeting to be held in Madras. ‘The practical steps’ to be taken for carrying ‘on of the company’s business on sound and efficient lines in the future’ would then be proposed.[64]

After a thorough analysis, the report concluded that ‘the company must either be ended, or its work mended’. Though winding up the company would be easy, the loss would be enormous. Before taking such a step, the company believed that, notwithstanding the earlier losses, a renewal of a regular steamer service between Tuticorin and Colombo along with coastal services (up to Calcutta) would yield some profits if Rs 2 lakh were raised within two months. This amount was necessary to meet the cost of new boilers and their fitting, clearing the accumulated dues in Bombay and Colombo and having a minimum amount as working capital. It was also decided to move both steamers to Tuticorin from Colombo to avoid the piling harbour dues.[65] Pointing out that a few steamship companies were working profitably in Bengal, the directors suggested that its future management be entrusted to a competent business firm in one of the presidency cities.